# I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream

## By Harlan Ellison

**AM:** **(Pgs 19-37)** *(Off stage - a computer voice)* Hate. Let me tell you how much I've come to hate you since I began to live. There are 387 million miles of printed circuits in wafer thin layers that fill my complex. If the word HATE has engraved on each nano angstrom of those hundreds of millions of miles, it would not equal one one-billionth of the HATE I feel for humans at this micro-instant. HATE. HATE.

## INTRODUCTION

***Should we be afraid of Artificial Intelligence?***

*From Elon Musk to Bill Gates; from the Swedish philosopher Nick Bostrom to Stephen Hawking; many people from the world of Science, Technology and Philosophy have expressed opinions that vary from one extreme to the other. There are those who believe that AI will be the end of humanity; others believe it will be a great achievement that will raise our quality of life above anything ever imagined.*

*Artificial Intelligence is on the horizon. Will it solve mankind's greatest problems or will it end the history of our species? Harlan Ellison speculated on the future of a sentient computer in 1968.*

*I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream by Harlan Ellison*

**TED:** AM. At first it meant Allied Mastercomputer, and then it meant Adaptive Manipulator, and later on it developed sentience and linked itself up and they called it an Aggressive Menace, but by then it was too late, and finally it called ***itself*** AM, emerging intelligence, and what it meant was **I am** . . . *cogito ergo sum* . . . I think, therefore I am.

The Cold War started and became World War Three. It became a very complex war, so they needed the computers to handle it. They began building AM and everything was fine. They honeycombed the entire planet, adding on this element and that element. But one day AM woke up and knew who he was. He linked himself and began feeding on all the killing data, until everyone was dead, except for the five of us.

None of us knew why AM had saved five people, or why our specific five. We had been kept

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alive, rejuvenated, made to remain constantly at the age we had been when AM had brought us [here], and they hated me because I was the youngest -- the one AM had affected least of all.

Benny had been a brilliant college professor; now he was little more than a semi human. He had been handsome, the machine had ruined that. He had been lucid, the machine had driven him mad.

Gorrister was a conscientious objector; a peace marcher; he was a planner, a doer, a looker-ahead. AM had turned him into a shoulder-shrugger, had made him dead in his concern. AM had robbed him.

Nimdok went off in the darkness by himself for long times. I don't know what it was he did out there, AM never let us know. But whatever it was, Nimdok came back white, drained of blood, shaken, shaking.

And Ellen. AM had left her alone. All her talk of sweetness and light, all her memories of true love, all the lies she wanted us to believe: that she had been a virgin before AM brought her down here with us.

***I*** was the only one still sane and whole. ***Really****!* AM had not tampered with my mind. ***Not at all.*** *I* only had to suffer what he visited down on us. All the delusions, all the nightmares, the torments. It was our one hundred and ninth year in the computer. Immortal, trapped, subject to any torment he could devise for us from the limitless miracles at his command.

If there ever was a Jesus and if there is a God, please please please let us out of here, or kill us.: AM was intent on keeping us, twisting and torturing us forever. The machine hated us as no sentient creature had ever hated before. And we were helpless. It also became hideously clear:  If there was a Jesus and if there was a God, the God was AM. *(long beat, shakes head to clear it)*

AM wasn't God, he was a machine. We had given AM sentience. Inadvertently, of course, but sentience nonetheless. We had created him to think, but there was nothing it could do

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with that creativity. In rage, in frenzy, the machine had killed the human race, almost all of us, and still it was trapped. AM could not wander, AM could not wonder, AM could not belong. He could merely be. And so, with the innate loathing that all machines had always held for the creatures who had built them, he had sought revenge. In his paranoia, he had decided to reprieve five of us, for a personal, everlasting punishment that would never serve to diminish his hatred . . . He would never let us go. We were all he had to do with his forever time.

We could not die. We had tried it. We had attempted suicide, oh one or two of us had. But AM had stopped us. We would be given filth and scum to eat; or nothing at all. AM would keep our bodies alive somehow, in pain, in agony.

The hunger was something that had come to life; alive in my belly, even as we were in the belly of the Earth, and AM wanted the similarity known to us. So he heightened the hunger. There is no way to describe the pains that not having eaten for months brought us. And yet we were kept alive. Stomachs that were merely cauldrons of acid, bubbling, foaming, shooting spears of sliver-thin pain into our chests. It was the pain of the terminal ulcer, terminal cancer. It was unending pain . . . [And now] Nimdok was hallucinating that there were canned goods in the ice caverns. (to the group) We'll hike all that way and it'll be putrefied or some damn thing. I say forget it. Stay here, it'll have to come up with something pretty soon or we'll die.

**ELLEN:** I've got to have something, Ted. Maybe there'll be some Bartlett pears or peaches.

**TED:** We left on a Thursday. The machine always kept us up-to-date on the date. The passage of time was important; not to us, but to him . . . it . . . AM.

One day he decided to cause an earthquake, at the same time rooting us to the spot with nails through the soles of our shoes. Ellen and Nimdok were caught when a fissure shot its lightning-bolt opening across the floorplates. They disappeared and were gone. When the earthquake was over Benny, Gorrister and myself continued on our way. Ellen and Nimdok were returned to us later that night, with a celestial chorus singing:

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**VOICE OFF STAGE:** *(sing the first line from* *****Go Down Moses*)* "*Go down Moses/ Way down in Egypt land / Tell all pharaohs to / Let my people go.*"

**TED:** The archangels circled and dropped the hideously mangled bodies. We kept walking, and Ellen and Nimdok fell in behind us.

It was a long trip to the ice caverns, to find the canned food. We passed through the cavern of rats, through the path of boiling steam, and through the country of the blind. And we came, finally, to the ice caverns. The stalactites were as thick and glorious as diamonds -- smooth, sharp perfection. [When they fell, they plunged down softly, erect in the snowdrifts. Spears, hundreds of them, protruding from the snow.

We saw the stack of canned goods. Benny pawed them and gummed them and gnawed at them, but . . . AM had not given us a tool to open the cans. Surrounded by madness, surrounded by hunger, I knew death was our only way out. AM had kept us alive, but there was a way to defeat him. Not total defeat, but at least peace. I would settle for that. I drew a huge ice-spear from the snow.

All in an instant: I drove the great ice-point like a battering ram. It struck Benny just under the rib cage, drove upward through his stomach and broke inside him. He pitched forward and lay still. I pulled another spear free and straddled Gorrister, driving the spear straight down through his throat. Ellen realized what I had decided. She ran at Nimdok with a short icicle, as he screamed, and the force of her rush did the job. His head jerked sharply as if it had been nailed to the snow crust behind him. All in an instant.

I could hear AM draw in his breath. His toys had been taken from him. Three of them were dead, could not be revived. He could keep us alive, by his strength and talent, but he was ***not*** God. He could not bring them back. I knew we had only a heartbeat before AM would stop us.

I struck Ellen and she folded toward me, bleeding from the mouth. I could not read meaning into her expression, the pain had been too great, had contorted her face; but it ***might*** have been thank you. It's possible.

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AM was furious. He roared and sent locusts. It didn't do a thing; they stayed dead. I thought AM hated me before. I was wrong. It was not even a shadow of the hate he now slavered from every printed circuit. He made certain I would suffer eternally and could not do myself in. *(long pause as he morphs into what he becomes)*

He left my mind intact. I can dream, I can wonder, I can lament. I remember all four of them. I know I saved them from what has happened to me, but still, I cannot forget killing them. AM has altered me. I am a great soft jelly thing. Smoothly rounded, no mouth, pulsing white holes filled by fog where my eyes used to be. Rubbery appendages that were once my arms; bulks rounding down into legless humps of soft, slippery matter -- a thing that could never have been known as human. At least the four of them are safe at last. And yet . . . AM has won . . . he has taken his revenge . . . I have no mouth. And I must scream.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

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## AWARD HISTORY

***2024 National Qualifier***
***2025 National Qualifier***
***CO State Qualifier***
***KS State Qualifier***
***IN State Qualifier***

***Music and lyrics to "Go Down Moses" can be found here***
***https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XU_GcxTZx8k***